

Book Two Title

Fracture and Flame

Book Two of the Techrot
Saga

2/ Chapter One

Book II Chapter I: "A Leaf Turned Over"

The sun rose lazily over the horizon, casting golden hues over the wide clearing the group now called home. A gentle breeze rustled the tall grass, and the distant sound of the river running nearby was a familiar hum in the background. Birds chirped. The occasional groan of reinforced scrap metal creaked in the wind. For the first time in a long time, the world felt still.

It had been a year since they left their last camp behind.

The horrors of that time were buried deep, tucked beneath laughter and long days of rebuilding. No one really talked about what had happened anymore. Not the invasion. Not Adam. Not Allison. Not even Azariah.

Especially not Azariah.

Kevin stretched with a loud yawn, stepping out of the supply hut while chewing lazily on a handful of pistachios he definitely wasn't supposed to have. His vest was half-buttoned, and his boots were untied. He scratched the back of his head as he looked around the camp — new walls, better defenses, a water system Levi had recently overhauled.

Levi.

The new tinkerer had been with them for about eight months now, quiet and curious, not nearly as excitable as Adam but somehow just as dependable. With short, messy hair usually smudged with oil, and a mind that rarely stopped thinking, Levi had earned the group's trust without trying too hard. He didn't smile often, but when he did, it was warm. Earnest.

He was bent over a disassembled drone now, muttering something about power regulators and shielding plates. Michael stood beside them, helping out where he could and cracking jokes that Levi either ignored or didn't understand.

"Camp grid's solid," Levi mumbled, adjusting a wire. "This thing should work like a roaming scout. Just... give me a few more days."

"You said that last week," Michael grinned.

Levi rolled his eyes.

Not far away, Marianna and Marie sat side by side, weaving baskets from dried reeds by the riverbank. It was something Marianna had picked up during their travels, a way to keep her hands busy. The deep scars on her arm from the hounds had faded but still ached in the cold. She worked in silence, occasionally glancing up to meet Marie's eye.

"We've come a long way, huh?" Marie said quietly.

Marianna nodded. "Yeah... We really did."

The tone was soft. Reflective. The two girls had found a rhythm again, no longer driven by survival but by the gentle cadence of routine. The grief hadn't vanished — it never could — but it had dulled, reshaped itself into something manageable.

Robert and Jadrien were patching the perimeter fence, arguing over which direction the support beams were supposed to face.

"Bro, I'm telling you, the brace goes *inward*. Think of pressure points!" Jadrien insisted, wielding a wrench like a sword.

Robert grunted. "You've never used a wrench in your life. Don't start now."

"Correction: I've *seen* it used. Same thing."

Despite himself, Robert chuckled. Even Jadrien, the clown of the group, had grown more grounded this past year. His eyes still held a shadow, but he buried it beneath humor and harmless nonsense.

Alex, now a little taller, a little more confident, helped Sage lay out preserved rations. He no longer clung to others. He *belonged* now. The group was his home, the people his family. He laughed when Jadrien tossed a bent fork at him. He smiled as Sage ruffled his hair.

Kevin watched them all for a moment. A strange calm had settled here. Peace. It was real. He rubbed his neck and looked down at the pistachio shell in his hand, suddenly feeling like it weighed more than it should.

He hadn't thought of that night in months. Not really. Not deeply.

But sometimes — when things got too quiet — he still saw the look on Adam's face as they turned away.

He shoved the shell into his pocket.

No one ever brought it up. No one ever questioned Jadrien's story again. But Kevin knew. And Jadrien knew that he knew.

Still, Kevin smiled and waved as Levi passed by, holding another coil of wire.

"You ever sleep?" Kevin asked.

"Once. In '23," Levi replied flatly.

Kevin laughed.

Another day began.

The air was cleaner here. The sun felt less cruel. The infestation still roamed the world beyond, but within these walls, they had carved something out for themselves. A slice of normal.

They were still broken in ways. But stitched back together.

Not perfect. Never perfect.

But good.

Very good.

2/ Chapter Two

Book II – Chapter II: Ghost in the Gears

The early morning light filtered through the trees like soft gold, catching on the dew still clinging to the tall grass outside camp. The air was cool — not cold, but calm. The kind of quiet that felt like the world itself had taken a deep breath and paused.

Alex adjusted the straps on his pack, glancing over at Levi who was crouched near the supply crates, double-checking their tools and emergency flares. Levi was always like that — methodical, cautious, but calm. There was no rush in his movements, just practiced patience.

“You ready?” Alex asked.

Levi looked up and offered a short nod. “Yeah. Food, medicine, wire, and maybe a few parts for the solar grid if we’re lucky.”

They exchanged a few more words with Marie and Robert before slipping through the worn gate that marked the edge of their encampment. The metal hinges creaked as they closed it behind them. Then they were alone, their footsteps muffled by the dirt road that stretched ahead.

For a while, they didn’t speak.

Alex didn’t mind. It had taken time to find comfort in silence, but now it felt like an old blanket — something you could wrap around yourself without needing to explain why.

“Hey,” Levi said after a few minutes. “Is this your first run without someone else from the original crew?”

Alex thought about that. “Yeah,” he answered quietly. “First since... before everything changed.”

Levi didn’t ask what “everything” meant. He didn’t have to.

They passed the skeleton of an old billboard, its surface peeled and sun-bleached, barely holding together under the weight of time. Vines snaked up its metal supports. On the cracked pavement below, tufts of grass fought through every fracture in the concrete, thriving in the broken places.

“You ever think it’s weird?” Levi said, eyes scanning the roadside. “That it’s been a year and there are still echoes of them everywhere?”

Alex glanced sideways. “Who?”

“The people before. You find little things — toys, scribbled notes, broken glasses. Like they’re still here, just invisible.”

Alex didn’t answer. His hands tightened around his pack straps.

After another mile, they reached the outskirts of the old tech depot. The building stood half-collapsed, metal siding bent like torn paper, windows broken, and vines overtaking what little structure remained.

Inside, shadows loomed.

Alex reached for the flashlight clipped to his belt and clicked it on. "Let's be careful."

"Always," Levi said with a faint grin.

They stepped over the threshold into the cool dark. The floor was littered with debris: metal shavings, fallen support beams, rusted crates. Old shelving units leaned precariously along the walls. Nature had started to reclaim it — moss coating the floor tiles, small plants sprouting from cracks.

"Split up?" Levi asked.

Alex shook his head. "Let's stick together."

They moved slow. Measured. Alex kept his eyes on every corner, every rustling sound. Despite the silence, something gnawed at the back of his mind — that subtle itch you get when you're being watched.

Then he saw it.

Perched on a broken filing cabinet near the far wall was a crow. But not a real one. No flapping of wings, no twitching of feathers. This was mechanical — sleek, matte black metal with intricate, moving parts. Its head moved, smooth and soundless, tracking them.

"Levi," Alex said, voice low. "Don't move."

Levi followed his gaze and froze.

"What is that?"

"It's not TechRot," Alex said slowly. "It's... something else."

The crow tilted its head. One eye glinted faintly — a pale green light pulsing within its socket. It didn't make a sound. It didn't threaten. It just... watched.

Alex took a slow step forward. "Shoo."

The crow didn't move.

Another step. "Shoo, damn it!"

Still nothing.

Frustration sparked. Alex snatched a wrench from the floor and hurled it.

The crow leapt — a fluid, impossible movement — dodging with ease and fluttering up to a nearby shelf. The wrench clanged against the wall and fell uselessly to the floor.

And then the voice came.

A warped, slightly distorted voice through the crow's chest speaker — like it had aged, been run through static — but still recognizable beneath the noise.

"That is no way to treat the creation of your old friend now, is it, kiddo?"

Alex froze.

The room spun. His breath caught. His heart pounded like it had been yanked from sleep.

The voice — *that* voice — echoed in his chest more than his ears.

"...Adam?" he whispered.

Levi stared at the crow, completely lost. "Alex? What's going on?"

The crow shifted its wings and clicked slightly, that glowing eye still locked onto Alex.

"I said—" Alex took a step forward, then faltered. "Say it again."

The crow didn't repeat itself. It only tilted its head again — an uncanny motion that looked *too* deliberate. Too familiar.

Levi took a cautious step toward Alex. "You okay?"

Alex didn't answer. His lips parted like he might speak, but the words didn't come. His mind was racing backward — to the sound of Adam laughing while soldering a broken transmitter, to the feel of warm metal tools passed hand to hand, to that odd nickname "*kiddo*" Adam had always used, even when no one else did.

He was shaking now.

It didn't make sense. Adam was gone.

But the voice...

The crow.

The speaker clicked once more. This time, it made no sound.

Levi finally said, "Alex, *what is that thing?*"

Alex barely heard him. He took another trembling step forward.

“...He’s alive,” he said, barely a whisper. “Somewhere...”

And then — silence. No more words. The crow unfolded its wings again, mechanical plates sliding open like puzzle pieces. It rose into the air and glided out a broken window, vanishing into the sky.

Alex ran forward, but by the time he reached the ledge, it was already gone.

Levi caught up behind him, panting slightly. “What the hell was that?”

Alex didn’t answer.

The building was quiet again. But the silence didn’t feel peaceful anymore.

Something had changed.

2/ Chapter Three

Book II – Chapter III: Watcher on the Wire

They gathered supplies in silence.

Levi kept the checklist in one hand, crossing off items with slow strokes of his pencil: nonperishables, bandages, spare batteries, low-gauge wire. But every so often, he'd glance over at Alex, brows pinched.

Alex moved through the wreckage like a ghost, his motions careful but distant. He kept stealing glances at the broken window where the crow had vanished. His hands trembled slightly when he packed up the last of the ration boxes.

He hadn't said a word since the crow spoke.

Levi finally broke the silence. "You're sure you're okay?"

Alex didn't answer at first. Then, barely audible: "Yeah."

But he wasn't. His eyes stayed trained on every shadow. On the rafters. The corners. The empty ceiling. And eventually, the crow returned.

It perched on the top edge of a leaning steel beam, talons clicking softly as they shifted for balance. It didn't move closer. It didn't speak. It simply watched.

Alex avoided its gaze, but Levi couldn't take his eyes off it. "It's been following us."

"I know."

"You still think it's Adam?"

Alex tightened the strap on his pack and started walking. "I don't know what I think."

The walk back to camp was long and quiet. Overgrown streets stretched ahead like empty veins. The wind rustled through broken windows and tree roots cracked the pavement. And always — *always* — the crow stayed behind them. Never more than thirty feet. Never less than ten.

It didn't fly. It walked, clicking metal claws softly against the concrete, pausing only when they did.

Even Levi, usually even-tempered and methodical, was unnerved.

"You don't think it's dangerous?" he asked at one point.

"If it wanted to hurt us," Alex murmured, "it had plenty of chances."

That shut Levi up.

By the time they returned to the gate, the sun was dipping low in the sky, casting the camp in warm golds and long shadows. Kids were boiling water near the fire pit. Robert was organizing gear near the weapon rack. Marie stood on the edge of the garden, arms crossed, watching them approach.

Then her eyes shifted — past them — to the crow.

“What the hell is *that*?”

They stopped just inside the perimeter. Alex turned. The crow clicked its way past the gate and hopped lightly up to a wooden platform near the tents. It paused there, surveying the camp, then with a flutter of metal wings, it launched itself upward — and landed neatly on the curved top of Alex’s tent.

As if it had always belonged there.

A few people muttered under their breath. Marie looked from Alex to the crow, then back again. “Alex—?”

“I need to talk to you,” Alex said quickly. “You and Jadrien and Marianna.”

She hesitated. “Is this about—?”

“Just... come on.”

They followed him to the far side of camp where the noise faded and the trees offered a little shade. Marianna was already nearby cleaning a knife; she glanced up as they approached and immediately frowned when she saw the expression on Alex’s face.

“What happened?”

Alex glanced around, checking for listening ears, then launched into the story — from the supply run to the crow’s voice, the dodge, the nickname, the moment it landed on his tent like it knew who he was.

“...and I swear, it was his voice. Not just *similar*. I *knew* it.”

Marianna’s lips parted, eyes wide. Marie crossed her arms again but didn’t speak.

Jadrien, leaning against a low tree, was quiet.

Too quiet.

His arms had stiffened at his sides. His jaw tensed ever so slightly.

Alex noticed.

“What?”

“Huh?” Jadrien blinked and forced a grin. “You think some busted drone with a soundboard is Adam?”

“I didn’t say that,” Alex replied. “But you seem... nervous.”

“I’m not nervous.” Jadrien looked away. “I just think we’ve seen enough fake-outs and ghosts to last a lifetime.”

“But *you* were there,” Alex said slowly, eyes narrowing. “That night. When he left.”

Marianna looked between them now, expression darkening. “Jadrien—”

“We all mourn differently, alright?” he snapped, a little too fast. “Sometimes things just *die*. You don’t go chasing every rusty bird because it reminds you of someone who isn’t here anymore.”

Silence.

Levi stepped up, hesitant. “Even if it *isn’t* Adam... shouldn’t we at least try to find out where it came from? Who made it?”

Jadrien shook his head, already backing off. “Nope. That thing’s a dead end. You can poke at it all you want, but I’m not going to chase shadows. Not anymore.”

He turned and walked off without another word.

Alex stood still, jaw clenched, watching him disappear between tents.

“...He *knows* something,” he whispered.

Marie ran a hand through her hair. “Maybe. But Jadrien doesn’t tell unless he wants to.”

“What do we do?” Marianna asked.

Alex turned, looking back toward his tent. The crow was still there — unmoving, eyes glowing faintly, waiting.

“I think,” he said quietly, “we figure out what it *really* wants.”

2/ Chapter Four

Book II – Chapter IV: Footsteps in the Dust

The morning was warm, humid with the soft promise of rain.

Camp buzzed in quiet, routine motion — Levi adjusting solar panels on the perimeter, Robert sharpening blades by the fire pit, and Sage moving through the herb garden with her usual quiet concentration. The air carried a fragile sense of normalcy. But it wasn't quite right.

Because the crow was moving.

Not flying — never flying — but *walking*. Deliberate. Mechanical. Its sleek black talons clicked sharply against the cracked concrete like a metronome, echoing through the otherwise gentle morning. It didn't skitter or flutter. It *strolled*. Like it had all the time in the world.

And it wasn't watching *everyone* now.

Just Marie.

She noticed it when the clicks began circling the far edge of the cookfire. At first, she thought it was scavenging — some leftover wiring, a piece of rusted tin. But then the crow changed direction.

Click.

Click.

Click.

It approached slowly, as if savoring the moment.

Marie froze. She didn't flinch — she never did — but her hand shifted slightly closer to the hilt of her blade.

The crow stopped three feet away. Its head tilted to one side.

Then, from its chest, that voice crackled to life — *grainy*, like an old radio:

"It's been a while, hasn't it?"

Marie's entire body locked.

Her breath hitched once, so faintly it could've been mistaken for the wind. But her eyes—her eyes—darkened like storm clouds rolling in.

"...Say that again," she said coldly.

The crow didn't move. Its lenses whirled, focusing slightly. Then it repeated:

"It's been a while, hasn't it?"

She stared at it, unmoving. The others hadn't noticed yet — too busy, too far, and the voice had spoken softly, low and even. But Marie felt the heat flush under her skin. That voice. That *voice*.

Not just similar. *Exact*.

The modulation, the pauses. The warmth buried beneath static. It wasn't a guess anymore.

It was *Adam's*.

She crouched slowly to the crow's eye level.

"What the hell are you?" she whispered.

The crow tilted its head the other way, whirring faintly, but said nothing more. Its inner mechanisms ticked faintly, audible now that she was this close — not crude or jagged like TechRot, but precise. *Crafted*. Smooth.

Handmade.

She gritted her teeth. "You're a puppet."

The crow gave no reply.

"I don't know who sent you, or why you're wearing *his voice*, but if this is someone's sick joke—"

"He said you'd say that," the crow replied suddenly.

Marie recoiled like she'd been struck. "What?"

"He said you'd say it was a trick."

For a moment, time stopped. Only the distant clatter of pots and the hum of wind.

Her voice cracked now, barely above a breath. "He... who?"

But the crow's eyes blinked — two mechanical shutters closing and opening with a tiny hiss — and it turned.

Without another word, it resumed its walk, talons clacking against stone, weaving past the water barrels and into the low brush beyond the eastern tents. Not in a hurry. Not retreating.

Just moving.

Marie sat back on her heels.

She hadn't realized her hands were shaking until she looked down and saw her fingers twitch. She didn't tell anyone. Not yet.

Not when Levi asked if she was okay. Not when Sage offered her a bowl of dried berries with a concerned glance. Not even when Marianna passed by and said, quietly, "It's watching all of us now."

Marie just nodded and returned to her spot beside the fence line, carving the edge of her blade sharper and sharper, as if she could scrape the unease out of her bones with steel.

But that night, after the fires dimmed and camp began to fall quiet, she walked slowly to Alex's tent.

The crow was still perched on top, as if guarding him.

Watching her approach, but saying nothing.

Marie stood beneath it, staring up into its blinking eyes.

"...If you're really in there," she said, voice low, "you better have a damn good reason for all of this."

Then she turned and walked away.

And behind her, the crow's head followed—clicking softly to track her retreat.

2/ Chapter Five

Book II – Chapter V: Echoes of Guilt

The stars above the camp flickered behind thin clouds, cold and distant. A soft wind rattled through the scaffolding near the east wall, barely audible over the creaking tents and the occasional night chirp of distant insects. Most of the camp had quieted—Levi snoring softly near his scrap pile, Sage sleeping in her usual curled posture near the garden, Marianna and Marie turned away from the fire, backs to the dark.

But one tent was not silent.

Jadrien's tent rustled faintly. From within, muffled mutters and the gentle creak of shifting fabric could be heard—restless movement, maybe. He hadn't been sleeping well. Not for weeks.

And tonight... he would not sleep at all.

Because someone—or something—was waiting outside.

The crow.

It stood like a statue, hunched on the short wooden post by Jadrien's tent entrance. Not perched high. Not watching from afar. *Right there*. Directly in front.

Its lenses glowed dim red in the dark, twin eyes unblinking. The low hum of internal servos gave it an eerie, faint heartbeat. It didn't twitch. Didn't preen its wings. It just *watched*.

And when the flap of Jadrien's tent finally peeled open with a groggy grumble, he stepped out in bare feet, rubbing one eye, muttering, "Damn wind... forgot to tie—"

He froze.

The crow stood less than two feet away.

"...What the hell?" he mumbled, stumbling back. "You scared the crap out of me."

The crow's eyes refocused.

Whir.

Click.

Its talons shifted. One clawed foot forward.

Jadrien tensed. His posture stiffened into something more alert now. Defensive.

"What do you want?" he asked, voice sharp now. "You watching me or something?"

Then—

"You left me for dead."

The voice wasn't grainy this time. It wasn't warbled by static or softened by mechanical inflection.

It was *crystal clear*.

Adam's voice. Unfiltered. Crisp. Like he was standing right there. Like he'd never left.

Jadrien's expression twisted, panic flickering behind practiced nonchalance.

"Wh—no. No, shut up. You're not him."

The crow tilted its head.

"You left me for dead, Jadrien."

He staggered back a step, breathing heavier now. "That's not real. You're just some *thing*. Just... someone programmed this, some twisted prank—!"

The crow stepped forward again.

"You *watched* me bleed."

Jadrien's hands clenched into fists.

"Stop it. *Shut up!*"

But the crow didn't shout. Didn't chase. It only turned away.

Without another word, it began walking—slowly, with the same deliberate cadence—its talons clicking with eerie rhythm on the pavement.

Click.

Click.

Click.

And then it was gone.

Jadrien stood frozen at the flap of his tent, breath shallow, his throat tight and his hands trembling.

He didn't try to call it back. Didn't ask where it was going.

He just stared into the night for a long, long time.

2/ Chapter Six

Book II – Chapter VI: *Why Didn't You?*

The crow was gone.

Its absence was more than just a missing shape on the rooftops or the clicking of talons. It was a silence that clung to the camp like a fog, thick and heavy. Everyone felt it. Even those who hadn't paid the thing much mind before.

But for Sage, it was something else entirely.

She had heard it. In the night. The words it said to Jadrien.

"You left me for dead."

And she hadn't slept since.

That morning, she found Marie near the garden, tending to a few sprouts fighting to survive in the cooler season.

Marie glanced up. "You look pale," she muttered.

"I heard it," Sage said.

Marie raised a brow. "The crow?"

Sage nodded. "It said something to Jadrien last night."

Marie stilled. "What did it say?"

Sage hesitated. "It said... *'You left me for dead.'*"

Marie stared at her, as if trying to decide whether she'd heard correctly. Then she stood abruptly, brushing soil from her hands.

A minute later, they were storming across camp.

Jadrien was near the tool rack, pretending to fix a busted shovel handle. He looked up and smirked—until he saw Marie's expression.

"What?" he asked. "You lose another crow?"

"Cut the act," Marie snapped. "What did it say to you?"

He froze.

Sage stepped forward. "I heard it, Jadrien. I *heard* what it said."

Jadrien's jaw tightened. "It was just a glitch. A recording. Someone messing with us."

"That wasn't a glitch," Marie hissed. "That was Adam's voice."

Jadrien's shoulders tensed. "Even if it was Adam... what difference does it make?"

"Everything," Sage muttered.

From the other side of the camp, Kevin approached slowly. He'd been listening. He always listened. For once, his goofiness was nowhere in sight. His hands were clenched at his sides.

"Tell them the truth, Jadrien," he said quietly.

Jadrien turned. "Kevin, don't—"

Kevin shook his head. "No. I kept my mouth shut for too long. I thought I could live with it. But I can't."

Marie's eyes narrowed. "Live with what?"

Kevin exhaled. "We found him. Adam. A year ago. He wandered off. Said he needed time. When he didn't come back, we went looking. Me and Jadrien."

Silence fell.

"We found him," Kevin said, voice cracking. "He was mauled. Barely breathing. He looked at us... and—Jadrien said we should leave him. Said he'd take up space. That he'd slow us down."

Sage covered her mouth.

Marie's face was pale.

Kevin looked down. "I didn't want to leave him. But Jadrien... he said if I didn't shut up, he'd get me kicked out. Said no one would believe me."

There was a sound behind them. Footsteps. Fast.

Alex.

His face was red. His eyes wide.

"You WHAT?"

Everyone turned.

Alex stood there, trembling, eyes filled with fire and tears.

"You *left him?*" he shouted. "You just—left him out there?!"

"Alex," Jadrien started, "I thought he was dying—"

"YOU DON'T GET TO DECIDE THAT!" Alex screamed.

The entire camp went still.

Tears streamed down his face now, his fists clenched.

"You *could've brought him back!* You could've *tried!* Why didn't you try?! Why didn't you—*WHY?!*"

He broke into sobs, falling to his knees.

Kevin looked away, guilt etched deep into every line of his face. Jadrien didn't speak. He couldn't. His voice was gone.

Alex looked up again, eyes bloodshot.

"I hate you," he whispered. "I *hate* you both."

And with that, he turned and ran.

He found Marie minutes later, sitting alone behind the water barrels. She didn't say anything when he collapsed beside her, still shaking. She didn't interrupt when he poured out everything he'd held back—his confusion, his anger, his sadness so deep it had become a permanent ache.

Marie just listened.

When he was done, she placed a hand gently on his back.

"I'm sorry, Alex," she said softly.

"I just miss him," he mumbled.

"I do too," she said.

The camp felt colder that night. Not from the wind, but from the weight of truth finally unearthed—and the fractures it left behind.

2/ Chapter Seven

Book II – Chapter VII: *The Letter*

The camp had quieted again, but it wasn't peaceful. It was the silence of a storm passed, the kind that leaves everything scattered and broken in its wake. No one spoke much that evening. Meals were skipped. Fires burned low. The few voices that did surface were hushed, like they feared waking something fragile.

Alex sat under the stars for a long time.

He had cried all he could. There was nothing left now but an emptiness — and a simmering ache that pulsed with every heartbeat. He hadn't meant to scream like that. But maybe he had. Maybe it had all been waiting to pour out for months, tucked deep behind everything he'd tried to keep moving forward for.

He felt exhausted, and not just from crying.

Eventually, he stood and trudged toward his tent. The world felt heavier somehow, the path dim, as though the grief had darkened the ground beneath him.

When he pulled back the flap, he stopped.

There, resting gently atop his folded blanket, was an envelope. Not weathered or dirty. Clean. White. As if it had just been placed.

Alex stared for several seconds before picking it up with shaky hands. His name was scrawled on the front in a handwriting he hadn't seen in so long he almost forgot it. Almost.

He sat slowly, heart pounding now, and unfolded the letter inside.

Hey kiddo,

You've done a wonderful job keeping everyone alive.

I always knew you would.

I know things have been hard. I know people made mistakes — big ones. But you held them together. That's not easy. I'm proud of you for that.

If you want to talk, we can.

The place to meet is on the back of this note.

You may choose to bring the others, or not. That's on you. Either way, I'll be waiting.

Hope to see you soon.

— *Adam*

Alex stared at the letter, his hands trembling, eyes blurring all over again.

He flipped the page over.

There, in small handwriting, were coordinates. Ones that pointed not far — no more than half a day's travel. A real place. A real lead.

He clutched the letter to his chest, breath shallow.

Adam was alive.

He *had* to be.

No machine, no trick of the crow, no recorded message—*this* was real. This was Adam's handwriting. His words. *Him*.

Alex sat there for a long while, heart full of panic and hope all tangled together. He didn't know what to do. He didn't know who to trust with it — not yet.

But he knew one thing: tomorrow, he would go.

2/ Chapter Eight

Book II – Chapter VIII: *Choice*

The morning broke quiet.

Alex hadn't slept.

The letter never left his grip all night. He kept waking, checking, making sure it was real. By dawn, the paper was soft from being held too tightly, corners bent, edges worn. But the ink hadn't faded. Adam's words were still there.

Still waiting.

He emerged from his tent just as the sun broke across the treetops. The camp stirred slowly—Marianna feeding the fire, Marie brushing the dust from her coat, Sage checking the tools stacked along the tentline. They all looked tired, frayed at the edges like threadbare cloth.

They hadn't healed. Not really.

Not from *that*.

Alex walked toward them, hands clenched at his sides. His voice didn't shake when he spoke, but it was quieter than usual.

"I need to talk to you," he said.

Marie looked up first, blinking sleep from her eyes. "What is it?"

Alex glanced around. Levi was off by the stream. Jadrien was sharpening one of his knives behind the tents. Kevin—thankfully—was scavenging in the brush, still avoiding everyone's gaze.

It was now or never.

"I got a letter," Alex said. "Last night."

Marianna raised an eyebrow. Sage stopped her work.

Alex unfolded the note and held it out. "It was waiting for me in my tent. It's from Adam."

A silence fell that felt like the air had been sucked out of camp.

"*What?*" Marie whispered.

"I don't know how," Alex said. "But it's his handwriting. It's *him*. He said he wants to meet. Gave me a location. Not far. Just half a day from here."

Sage walked over slowly and read the note herself. Her lips parted slightly in surprise.

"It's real," she murmured.

"He might be alive," Marianna said under her breath. Her voice trembled — but not with fear. With something older. Something unfinished.

Alex folded the paper again and looked at them all.

"I'm going," he said. "With or without you. That's your choice."

Marie stepped forward, brows furrowed. "Alex—"

"I'm *going*," he repeated, firmer now. "You don't have to come. I'm not asking you to. But I *am* going."

Marianna took a breath like she wanted to argue... but didn't.

"You sure it's not a trap?" Sage asked quietly.

"No," Alex admitted. "But even if it is... it's one I need to walk into. For *him*. For all of us."

No one said anything.

The fire popped behind them, its crackle the only sound in the thickening tension.

Marie crossed her arms. "We can't tell Kevin. Or Jadrien. Or Levi. Not yet."

Alex nodded. "I wasn't going to."

"They'd try to stop us," Sage said. "Or worse."

Marianna's hands balled into fists. "We leave at dusk. Quiet. We take only what we need."

"Agreed," said Marie.

Alex looked at them all, something deep and raw moving behind his tired eyes.

"Thank you," he said softly.

And without another word, he turned away and began preparing.

2/ Chapter Nine

Book II – Chapter IX: *The Brick House*

Dusk fell like a blanket of ash, soft and dim.

The group moved quietly, every step measured. Their bags were light—only food, water, a few weapons, and what they hoped was enough courage. They said nothing as they left the camp, weaving through the tall grass and low brush that marked the edge of their temporary home. No goodbyes, no backward glances.

Just silence. And purpose.

It was Alex who led. His shoulders were tense, but his pace was steady, unwavering. The others followed behind: Marie, Marianna, and Sage. Their breath fogged slightly in the cooling air, and the orange streaks of sunset bathed the earth in a melancholy gold.

The path was easy. Familiar. No TechRot, no twisted metal roots, no corrupted trees. Only grasslands and ruined fence lines, rusted mailboxes, and the occasional silent road that hadn't seen a vehicle in years.

They were grateful for the stillness.

After an hour, Marianna broke the quiet.

"It's strange," she said. "Walking like this. Feels like a different life."

Alex glanced back. "It *was* a different life."

They walked a little longer before he spoke again, slower this time.

"Do you remember the first time Adam taught me how to fix the solar chargers?" he asked. "He didn't even explain anything at first. Just threw the wires at me and told me to try."

Marie chuckled. "Yeah. You nearly electrocuted yourself."

"I *did* electrocute myself," Alex corrected, grinning faintly. "And he laughed like it was the funniest thing in the world."

Sage smiled, a little tight around the edges. "He used to call you 'Sparkplug.'"

"He did," Alex said softly.

They kept walking. The stars came out above them, quiet companions blinking through the cloudless sky. The moonlight gave the tall grass a silver shimmer, and somewhere in the distance an owl hooted once—low and thoughtful.

“Do you remember that fire we built in the rain?” Alex asked. “When everything was soaked and the wind was against us?”

“That was when Azariah was still around,” Marianna said, her voice wistful. “He kept blowing on the embers like it would help.”

“And Adam used a broken radio coil to arc a spark through dry twine,” Marie added. “Like it was nothing.”

“We thought he was magic,” Alex murmured.

The memories clung to them, warm despite the chill. A thread tying them together as they pressed forward through the dark.

And slowly... the night began to turn pale.

By the time the sky lightened to a soft indigo, the house came into view.

It sat on a gentle rise, partially swallowed by ivy and surrounded by the soft hush of the waking world. A two-story brick structure, sturdy despite its years, with shattered windows repaired with mismatched panes of colored glass. A garden bloomed wildly at the sides, overrun but not unkempt.

And everywhere... machines.

They were small at first—two foxes sniffing the breeze from the brush, their metal tails twitching silently. Then cats, sleek and narrow-eyed, moving in perfect synchronization atop the fence. Birds lined the telephone wire—steel-feathered with blinking lenses for eyes. Wolves stood guard near the treeline, unmoving but aware.

The hounds flanked the path like statues.

All of them watched the group.

Sage stopped walking. “They knew we were coming.”

“No... they were *waiting*,” Marie said quietly.

Atop a small, rust-streaked shed near the house sat the crow.

It tilted its head slightly, eyes glowing a soft amber, before giving a low mechanical *click-click-click* with its talons on the tin roof. Then it spread its wings just enough to stretch—like a predator yawning.

Alex stepped forward first.

The door creaked as he opened it. The inside smelled like dust and old oil. There were books piled against the walls, blueprints scattered across a long table, shelves of parts sorted with meticulous care.

And then...

A voice.

Familiar. Soft. Not a recording—but real.

“Hello, old friends.”

2/ Chapter Ten

Book II – Chapter X: *Ashes Reforged*

There was a beat of stunned silence.

Then Alex stepped forward, lips parted, eyes already misting over. “Adam—”

Marie’s arm shot out, stopping him.

“Wait,” she said, her voice steady but sharp.

Alex froze, torn between joy and confusion. “But... it’s *him*.”

Marie didn’t lower her arm. “I know. But we need to hear him out first.”

Adam stood a few feet from them. He looked just as they remembered—slightly taller than most, the same calm, sharp eyes and tousled dark hair that always looked like he’d been tinkering too long to care. But now, where his right leg once had been, a crafted metal limb stretched from the knee down, subtle gears visible along the joint, polished but worn.

He didn’t look broken. Just... quieter.

Adam gave a small nod. “That’s fair,” he said, motioning to a long table surrounded by salvaged chairs. “Let’s talk.”

They sat slowly. Alex kept sneaking glances—his hands trembling in his lap. He didn’t understand why he wasn’t allowed to rush over, to throw himself into the one person he thought he’d lost forever.

Marie leaned forward, folding her hands on the table. “First question,” she said plainly, “the automatons.”

She nodded toward the window, where one of the mechanical cats paced by, its chrome joints clicking softly.

“Last time we trusted something like that,” she said, voice tightening, “Azariah died. So you’ll understand the hesitation.”

Adam nodded, the corners of his mouth drawing into something between sorrow and resolve.

“I get it. And I’d never bring TechRot near you—ever again,” he said. “These things... they’re not infected. Not even close. I designed them from scratch, built every piece with material that’s never been touched by the virus. I tested each one. Controlled AI, not sentient, not hive-mind. Just... helpers.”

He leaned back, eyes distant.

"I missed the grace of nature. The way it used to move before everything was corrupted. So I tried to recreate it."

The group was quiet. Outside, a pair of foxes trotted along the fence, stopping to nuzzle each other in silence.

Marie spoke again. "Next question," she said, her voice lower now. "Why didn't you come back? You clearly knew where we were."

Adam hesitated. For the first time since they'd walked in, he looked truly pained.

"I didn't know how to," he admitted. "After Kevin and Jadrien left me there, I—well, I didn't think I was going to survive. The hounds shredded my leg. It took eight months to recover... and most of that was just learning how to breathe without pain again."

He tapped the metal of his leg once, absently.

"I made the automatons during that time, at first just to have something that listened. Something to keep me from losing my mind."

He paused.

"After I healed, I could have come back. That's true."

"So why didn't you?" Marie asked softly.

"Because..." Adam looked down. "Jadrien's words stuck with me. That I'd just take up space. Be a burden. And with this—" he motioned to the leg again "—maybe he was right."

"You *weren't*," Alex said suddenly, voice sharp and cracking. "You *aren't*."

Adam's eyes flicked to him, then back to Marie.

"I didn't know if you'd want me back," he continued. "Or if you'd even believe I was still me. I figured you were better off moving on. But I hoped... maybe one day you'd come find me."

"And if we hadn't?" Marianna asked, quietly.

"I guess I would've kept making things," Adam said, giving a hollow smile. "Waiting."

Alex stood up abruptly, the scrape of his chair sharp against the floor. "We needed you."

Adam's gaze softened. "I know, kiddo. And I needed you too. Every day."

The room was quiet again, the only sound was the soft ticking of distant gears and the faint rustle of metal wings outside.

Adam glanced at each of them, eyes lingering just a little longer on Alex.

"I'm glad you came."

2/ Chapter Eleven

Book II – Chapter XI: *Unspoken Things*

Adam stood in the doorway, backlit by a soft, pale light spilling in from the sky that had finally warmed to dawn.

“Well,” he said, voice casual but not light, “I should let you talk. I’ve got things to tend to anyway. Repairs, feedings. The fox automaton keeps digging into the compost bin.”

He gave them a faint smile — more weary than warm.

“You’re welcome to stay as long as you need. Beds are upstairs. They’re clean. Mostly.” He gave a small chuckle, then turned, stepping off the porch with a soft *click* of his mechanical leg.

None of them moved. Not right away. They just watched him as he disappeared behind the shed again, the familiar ticking of his automatons resuming in the background like a steady, alien heartbeat.

The moment the door clicked shut behind him, the group let out a breath none of them realized they were holding.

“I—” Alex started, then stopped. He looked between them all, eyes flickering, unsure. “I want to stay with him.”

Marie turned to him, her voice firmer than he expected. “No.”

Alex blinked, stepping back slightly. “What? Why not? You saw him—he’s *alive*. He’s *him*.”

“I know,” she said quickly, before his voice could break again. “I know. But he’s also... not the same. None of us are. His peace—it doesn’t feel like ours. It’s... off.”

Marianna nodded slowly. “There’s something too still about this place. Too perfect.”

“He was left to rot,” Alex said, not shouting but barely keeping his emotions contained. “And he *survived*. He *built* this. How is that not a miracle?”

Robert finally spoke, arms crossed as he leaned against the wall. “It *is* a miracle. But we’ve seen miracles twist the wrong way before.”

“Then why did we even come here?” Alex asked, voice cracking. “If we weren’t ready to accept him, why did we come?”

Marie sighed, hand rubbing her temple. “Because we *wanted* to believe. But that doesn’t mean we know *how* to believe again.”

The group fell into silence. A quiet kind of silence — not judgmental, just uncertain. They stood in the dim living room of the old brick house, its walls patched up with scrap metal and draped in faded curtains, as though the house itself had forgotten what time it was supposed to belong to.

Marianna looked out the window where a pair of metal hounds slept beside the porch. “Last time we were with him... it was after Azariah died.”

No one said anything.

Marie finally sat down on one of the couches, eyes glazed with thought. “We associate Adam with the worst week of our lives. That kind of memory doesn’t wash off in one sunrise.”

Alex looked between them again, this time quieter, searching for something he couldn’t name in their faces.

“It’s not fair,” he whispered.

“It’s not,” Marie agreed gently. “But we’re here now. And we have to figure out what to do with that.”

Alex didn’t sit. He wandered to the window instead, staring out where the crow still perched motionless above the shed. It tilted its head slightly, like it knew he was watching.

Alex’s voice came again, low and uncertain. “So what now?”

No one answered. Because none of them knew.

And somewhere in the yard, behind the shed, the quiet, precise clinking of tools on metal echoed — a rhythm Adam had lived by for a year, alone.

2/ Chapter Twelve

Book II – Chapter XII: *The Shed in the Dark*

The house was quieter than any place they'd stayed in a long time.

No distant clicking of TechRot movement. No wind whistling through crumbling metal. Just the soft mechanical purring of the animal-like automatons outside and the creaks of an old home trying to remember it was a home again.

The group had claimed separate rooms, though no one slept soundly. Conversations had ended early, not because they were resolved, but because everyone had run out of questions they were brave enough to ask.

Alex lay staring at the ceiling. His hands rested over his chest, unmoving, his mind louder than the silence around him. The mattress was surprisingly soft, the blankets warm, but rest refused to come. The moonlight slanted across the floor, casting long shadows that pulsed slightly with the swaying trees outside.

He's here. He's real.

And yet... nothing felt settled.

After what felt like hours of stillness, Alex sat up, slipping from bed with careful movements. He opened the door gently, its hinges barely whispering as he crept into the hallway and then down the stairs.

The front door gave way to the cool night air, and he stepped onto the porch barefoot.

The courtyard of automatons was peaceful. The hounds lay curled together like oversized watchdogs. Birds slept on perches strung between old metal poles. The crow still sat near the shed, but it turned its head only slightly, as if acknowledging his presence before deciding it wasn't worth the energy to respond.

Alex walked past it, eyes drifting across the landscape.

Then he froze.

At the edge of the grove near the property's perimeter, a figure was moving. A lantern swung softly in their hand — casting a long, swaying silhouette over the tall grass.

Adam.

He wasn't heading toward any of the main buildings, but toward the back corner of the property — a stretch Alex hadn't explored yet. Something about Adam's posture was different. Less casual. Focused. Intentional.

Alex moved from the porch before he could think twice. Curiosity—and something deeper—tugged at his chest.

He stayed low, moving through the grass with practiced stealth. Years of surviving TechRot had taught him to breathe quietly, to place his feet carefully. He followed the faint flicker of Adam's lantern as it bobbed ahead, leading toward an old, half-sunken structure almost entirely hidden behind a curtain of ivy and fencing.

Adam reached the shed and paused.

Then, he tilted his head slightly.

"Al~ex..." he sang, low and lilting.

Alex's blood turned cold.

Adam hadn't turned around. He hadn't called out loud. But he *knew*.

Panic surged, and Alex instinctively took a step back — only to collide with something behind him.

A soft *whirr* echoed. Then the faint sound of metal shifting.

He turned his head slowly.

A wolf automaton stood behind him, eyes dim but focused. Its metal snout brushed against his shoulder, then nudged him — not harshly, but insistently — toward the shed.

Alex's breath caught in his throat.

The wolf nudged again, more firmly this time.

With trembling steps, Alex moved forward.

Adam stood calmly by the shed door, expression unreadable in the moonlight. He smiled, not unkindly.

"Curiosity gets the best of us all," he said softly. "But that's alright. You were meant to see this anyway."

Alex didn't respond. His eyes flicked between the wolf and Adam. His stomach twisted with something he couldn't name — fear, maybe. Or awe. Or both.

Adam turned to the shed door and placed his hand on it.

"There's something I've been waiting to show someone," he said, voice lower now, tinged with something almost reverent.

The old lock clicked open.

He looked back at Alex.

“Come on, kiddo. Let me show you what I’ve been working on.”

Then he opened the door.

2/ Chapter Thirteen

Book II – Chapter XIII: *The Door That Shouldn't Open*

The door creaked open with a groan that sounded older than the house itself.

Inside was blackness. Not just darkness — but a thick, swallowing void that seemed to consume the lantern light Adam held at his side.

Alex stepped back, the tension in his chest growing into something colder, sharper.

“Adam... what is this?” he asked, voice barely more than a whisper.

Adam didn't respond. He simply stepped aside, one hand still resting lightly on the shed door as if holding it open against some unseen weight.

A faint hiss escaped from within. Then, a green mist rolled out across the dirt, curling like living tendrils over the ground. It shimmered slightly under the moonlight — not bright, but familiar.

Too familiar.

Alex's eyes widened.

No. No, no—

He turned, bolting away from the shed—but Adam's foot swept out, catching him mid-step.

Alex hit the dirt hard, the wind knocked from his lungs. Panic clawed its way up his throat as he scrambled, trying to rise.

“Adam! What are you doing?!” he shouted.

“I'm sorry, kiddo.”

Adam's voice cracked.

From the darkness of the shed, something surged.

A slick, sinewy tentacle — green-veined and pulsing with sickly, biomechanical life — lunged from the shadows and wrapped tightly around Alex's leg.

“No—!” Alex screamed, grabbing at the ground, clawing for purchase as he was pulled backward.

Adam didn't move.

Tears slid down his face silently, cutting clean lines down his dirt-covered cheeks.

Alex's hands grasped for anything. Rocks, grass, dirt. His fingers left trenches in the soil as the tentacle dragged him closer to the darkness, to the place where the gas seeped from and the air crackled with unnatural tension.

"I'm sorry..." Adam whispered again, eyes not leaving Alex's.

The shed door slammed shut.

Silence fell over the grove once more.

Morning came slowly, and with it, unease.

Marie was the first to rise, her eyes bleary as she stepped outside the house into the soft morning light. The automatons were still there — some perched, some walking — but she noticed something was off.

No sign of Adam.

And more importantly, no sign of Alex.

By mid-morning, concern turned to dread.

"He wouldn't just leave," Marie muttered, pacing.

Marianna agreed, and Sage had already started checking the edge of the grove for tracks. The house was searched top to bottom, Levi trying to stay calm but his movements increasingly frantic.

They spent the day scouring the surrounding forest, splitting into pairs. But there was nothing. No footprints. No sound. Not even a trace of Adam's presence.

As the sun dipped behind the tree line and long shadows began to stretch over the property, Adam finally returned.

He walked out of the woods quietly, carrying a small bundle of firewood in his arms, face unreadable.

Marie rushed toward him. "Where the hell have you been? Where's Alex?"

Adam didn't stop walking.

"He left," Adam said flatly. "He went back to camp early this morning."

"What? Why would he do that alone?" Marianna asked, brows furrowing.

Adam didn't answer.

"He just... left?"

“Yes.” His voice was emotionless. “He said he needed space. I didn’t stop him.”

Silence rippled through the group. It didn’t feel right — didn’t *sound* right. Something in Adam’s voice was off. Too rehearsed. Too hollow.

“The forest isn’t safe at night,” he added, shifting the firewood in his arms. “You should all get some rest. We’ll leave tomorrow. Early.”

Sage stepped forward, staring at him.

“Adam,” she said cautiously. “You’re not saying everything.”

He looked up at her. But I didn’t speak.

The moment hung heavy.

Then, with an calm smile, he turned toward the house.

“We should sleep.”

And just like that, he walked inside.

Leaving the others in the dark.

Literally — and now, deeply — figuratively.

2/ Chapter Fourteen

Book II – Chapter XIV: *Echoes in the Dark*

Marie's eyes snapped open.

The room was wrong.

Cold stone surrounded her. The air was thick, damp, and choked with the smell of rust and decay.

She tried to sit up, but her limbs were weak — heavy, like she'd been drugged.

Dim pulses of green light traced the edges of the room, just enough to see the writhing, sluggish movements of tentacles that lined the walls and ceiling. Biomechanical. Glinting slightly in the dark.

"Where the hell—"

She wasn't the only one waking.

Marianna groaned from her left, eyes wide with confusion and growing horror as she sat up.

"What... what is this?"

Sage stirred next. Robert. Levi. Even Jadrien, though he looked worse than the rest — pale and shaking, mumbling something incoherent under his breath.

And then...

"Alex!" Marie gasped, crawling toward the corner of the cell where the youngest of them sat, knees pulled to chest, face pale and haunted.

"I—I didn't know," he whispered. "I didn't know this is what he meant."

Before Marie could answer, the sound of footsteps echoed outside their cell.

Click... click... click...

A figure approached slowly, pacing along a metal catwalk that overlooked their prison.

It was Adam.

His posture was stiff. His movements oddly graceful, like a puppet with strings too taut. His eyes glowed a deep, unnatural orange, swirling faintly with the same green shimmer of the mist from the shed.

He stopped at the edge of the platform, crouched, and leaned forward.

A smile tugged at his face. Too wide.

“Hey, friends,” he said, voice light and casual — a mimicry of Adam’s usual tone. “Comfy?”

No one answered.

His gaze flicked briefly to Alex.

“In case there were doubts, yes — he’s alive. Kept him safe. Had to. You wouldn’t understand just how valuable he is.” He tapped the side of his temple. “But I do.”

Marianna stood, hands curling into fists. “That’s not Adam. Those aren’t his eyes.”

The creature smiled wider. “Yes, you’re right, as always, kid. It’s not *him*. But I do *express* him. Every locked-away feeling. Every drop of rage. Every second of being abandoned. Left behind in the dirt to rot. To starve. To crawl.”

His voice deepened slightly — distorted at the edges. Less human.

Alex backed away, breathing ragged.

“Why are we here?” Marie snapped.

The thing that wore Adam’s face tilted its head.

“Because you’re useful,” it said. “You see, human DNA — your genome — can revert TechRot. Not completely, not yet. But I’m close. With *him*”—he pointed at Alex—“I’m even closer. Your little protector has something special inside. Something new.”

Jadrien stumbled forward, eyes wild. “You’re lying. You’re using him.”

“Oh, of course I am,” the voice crooned. “But not like you did.”

It stood.

The catwalk dimmed behind it as it walked, disappearing into shadow. For a moment, there was silence.

Then the ceiling above them creaked. Slid open.

Something began to lower.

It was immense. A tangle of churning metal and flesh. A hulking, octopus-like TechRot mass that pulsed with green veins and orange eyes, its tentacles connected to every wall of the cell.

One of the tentacles slithered downward and coiled protectively around Adam as he stood still, letting it rise behind him like a throne of disease.

With a flick of its head, a hiss filled the room.

A gas vented from hidden ports along its body — thick, heavy, sickly sweet and tinged the same color as every nightmarish memory they'd fought so hard to escape.

"No!" Marie shouted, covering her mouth, trying to pull the others back.

But it was no use.

The gas was fast.

Sage collapsed first, then Robert and Levi. Marianna tried to hold on, swaying, but her knees buckled seconds later.

Marie's eyes locked with Alex's as the world started spinning.

"I'm sorry," he whispered.

And then he was gone — his eyes rolled back, limbs limp.

Marie tried to reach for him... but her vision darkened, her thoughts fragmenting into fog.

The last thing she saw before the void claimed her was the thing wearing Adam's face turning to walk away, surrounded by metal and rot.

And silence.

2/ Chapter Fifteen

Book II – Chapter XV: *Things We Left Behind*

They awoke in pieces — groggy, slow, each movement dulled like their bodies were wrapped in lead.

The first to open her eyes was Marie.

She couldn't move.

Thick TechRot tentacles slithered from the walls and ceiling, binding her wrists and ankles to the metal table she lay on. She tried to twist free, but the living cables only tightened, responding to her panic with mechanical indifference.

To her right, Marianna was restrained in the same way — already awake, her face pale and jaw clenched tight.

Jadrien. Sage. Robert. Levi. All of them, trapped on separate medical tables. Eyes wide, breaths sharp and frantic.

Alex was furthest from her — the last to stir. His head lulled to one side, eyes flickering open as the situation came into terrifying focus.

A familiar pair of footsteps echoed through the chamber.

Click.

Click.

Click.

Adam emerged from the shadows, arms behind his back. That unnatural orange glow still tainted his eyes. He looked too calm. Too casual.

"I'll be nice," he said smoothly, voice laced with a toxic politeness. "We'll talk before I get what I need."

He stopped beside Jadrien first, tilting his head like a curious animal.

"So tell me..." he murmured, smile sharp.

"How was it... *betraying* me, Jadrien?"

Jadrien's throat bobbed. "You weren't supposed to survive— I— It wasn't like that!"

"No?" Adam's grin didn't falter. "You threatened Kevin. You kept your mouth shut and left me for dead. That's the definition of betrayal, isn't it?"

Jadrien went silent, eyes filling with shame, but said nothing more.

Adam stepped slowly past him, coming to Marie's table.

"And you," he said. "How long did it take you to replace me, Marie?"

Marie stared him down. "No one replaced you. We *survived* without you."

"But that's the thing." Adam leaned in. "I was still there. A full week before I passed out. Bleeding, crawling, screaming your names until my throat gave out. Did you even look?"

"We thought you were dead," she hissed. "We buried what we had left."

"Ah. Convenient."

He stepped back, and his tone turned colder.

"People don't abandon those they care about," he said flatly. "Only the ones they were *using*."

The words echoed across the chamber like a verdict. No one could respond.

And then, Adam's eyes settled on Alex.

His expression shifted.

Softer. Regretful.

"Alex," he said, almost choking the name. "My dear friend. I'm sorry I had to use you."

The orange glow in his eyes flickered.
Then vanished.

His posture buckled, like something inside snapped — and the real Adam surfaced for just a moment.

"I didn't want to," he whispered, voice shaking. "I swear I didn't—"

The TechRot tendrils around his legs snapped taut, jerking him backward.

His eyes reignited, orange once more.

Without another word, he turned from them and disappeared into the dark, his silhouette merging with the octopus-like entity that had dragged them here.

Silence.

And the sound of metal breathing.

2/ Chapter Sixteen

Book II – Chapter XVI: *Flicker*

It started with a twitch.

Just one.

The twitch of a finger. Then the tilt of a head. The glow in Adam's eyes blinked off like a faulty light, revealing dull, human brown underneath. His breath hitched. His shoulders slumped. And for a moment, the monster was gone.

The room was still. The TechRot entity's tendrils hissed, reacting to the shift in energy — unsure of whether to recoil or tighten.

Adam staggered to the far wall and grabbed at his head, fingers curling in his hair.

"No, no— stop— not now—" he whispered, shaking violently.

Inside the cell, the group remained bound, wide-eyed, unmoving, unsure whether to hope or fear.

Alex strained against his restraints. "Adam?"

His name hit like a bullet.

Adam turned toward him — not with malice, but desperation.

"It's me," he choked out. "I don't have long."

The orange glow began to bleed faintly into the whites of his eyes again. He winced and reached into his jacket pocket, pulling something out. A small, rusted key on a thin chain.

He stumbled toward Alex's table, fighting every step like his own muscles were rebelling. He gritted his teeth, jaw clenched so tight it looked like it might shatter.

"I... I already made it," he breathed, pressing the key into Alex's palm. "The cure. I had it weeks ago. That thing— it doesn't *want* it. It wants *you all* dead. It doesn't need me anymore. I'm just—"

The orange flooded back.

Adam jerked like a marionette on severed strings, stumbling backward and slamming against the far wall. He screamed — a horrible, ragged cry that was too human to ignore.

The glow flickered again, warping, distorting — like his very skin was resisting the thing crawling underneath it.

He looked at Alex, one last time.

“Get out,” he whispered hoarsely. “Get out and don’t look back.”

And then he collapsed — and the glow returned with brutal finality.

The orange-eyed shell of Adam stood again. Straightened his posture. Cracked his neck.

When he spoke, the voice was smooth again. Detached.

“Nice try.”

And with that, the creature snapped its fingers — and the lights overhead plunged the room into darkness.

2/ Chapter Seventeen

Book II – Chapter XVII: The Price of Redemption

Smoke filled the air like a breath held too long, heavy and clinging to every surface. The lab pulsed with warning lights—red, urgent, flickering in a cadence that matched the growing tension. Alex's wrists burned from the coarse grip of TechRot tentacles that had bound him to the surgical table. His mind screamed to move, to run, to fight, but his limbs were still pinned. Beside him, the others writhed in similar states—Marie, Jadrien, Marianna, Kevin, Levi—each struggling, each terrified.

And across the room, Adam fought for his soul.

The man who had once been the group's brightest light stood at war with himself. His form twitched, convulsing as the orange glow flickered in his eyes—bright one moment, dim the next. He clutched at his skull as if trying to tear the possession out by force.

"You have to listen to me," Adam rasped, his voice human again for just a breath. "I built the cure. It's real. It works. But the TechRot—" he winced, the glow surging back—"it doesn't want a cure."

The TechRot lashed out in frustration, spawning twisted canines from its darkness—mechanical and organic fused in terrifying symmetry. Their jaws clicked open, dripping with black sludge, eyes glowing like burning coals. They sniffed the air and turned toward Alex.

The canine automatons pounced.

Alex sucked in a breath and twisted just as one lunged, its teeth scraping across the edge of the metal table. With a violent jerk, his left hand slipped free. He didn't think—there was no time to think. He swung his arm up and grabbed the scalpel Adam had dropped earlier in his inner conflict.

The second canine dove for him, but Alex rolled off the table just in time, landing hard on his shoulder. Pain exploded through his chest, but he scrambled to his feet. With shaking hands, he sawed at the tentacles holding Marie.

"Alex!" she cried, her voice hoarse with fear and desperation. "Behind you!"

He ducked, barely missing a clawed paw meant to decapitate him. The scalpel slashed through the last strand binding Marie, and she rolled to the floor and kicked the attacking creature square in the jaw, sending it staggering back.

"Help the others!" Alex yelled.

Together, they moved in desperate coordination, cutting the others free as the canines swirled around them. Jadrien grabbed a loose pipe and used it to bludgeon one of the beasts away from Kevin. Levi used a burning torch from the wall to drive back another.

Amid the chaos, Adam clutched the main control console. His hands flew across the interface, even as his body convulsed from the internal war raging within him.

"Do it," he muttered to himself. "You have to do it. For them. For everything."

He slammed his palm against a red button.

A low hum began, deep and resonant, as vials around the lab began to shatter, releasing a fine mist. Green at first—then clear. The infected vines recoiled. The TechRot screamed. Not in words, but in a raw, guttural pulse that echoed in every skull like nails on bone.

"RUN!" Adam screamed, his eyes briefly clear again. "The lab—it'll blow once the dispersal is done!"

The group hesitated—none of them wanting to leave him.

Alex locked eyes with Adam. "Come with us!"

"I can't," Adam replied, coughing blood now. "They're in me. If I leave, the infection does too. The cure—needs this."

Alex shook his head furiously. "We can fix this! We always fix this!"

"Not this time, kiddo," Adam smiled. It was tired. It was real.

Alex hesitated a second too long. A canine lunged. This time, Levi tackled it mid-air, roaring in defiance as it knocked him against the wall. Marianna and Marie grabbed Alex by the arms and dragged him, even as he kicked and screamed for Adam.

"No! No! I won't leave him again!"

"You have to!" Marie shouted over the rising hum. "He wants this—he's saving us!"

The exit door was barely visible through the smoke. The TechRot was unraveling, vines curling in agony, machines short-circuiting and collapsing. Alex twisted just in time to see Adam collapse near the console, one final smile on his face.

They burst through the door.

Alex stopped at the threshold.

He turned—just once—and saw Adam raise a hand in farewell.

Then everything behind them exploded in a flash of light and wind and fire.

The blast hurled them into the dirt outside. They rolled down the hillside, coughing, crying, shielding each other from the debris raining down. The automatons around the

compound—canines, foxes, crows—fell one by one, lifeless and silent. The forest beyond shivered as if exhaling.

And then... silence.

Smoke billowed from the brick house, now half-consumed by fire. The morning sun rose in slow defiance over the ruins.

The group lay sprawled in the grass, bruised, bleeding, and breathless. No one spoke for several long minutes.

Alex curled into himself and sobbed.

Marie crawled over and wrapped her arms around him.

"He saved us," she whispered, voice breaking. "He saved us all."

Jadrien sat up slowly, covered in soot, staring back at the smoking ruins. "After everything we did to him... he still saved us."

Kevin nodded, silent and ashamed.

Marianna lay flat on her back, staring at the sky. "That was the real Adam. That was him all along."

Alex finally sat up, wiping the tears from his eyes. His hands trembled as he held something—something small.

The key Adam had given him.

It glowed faintly in the morning light. The last piece of Adam, still warm with purpose.

"Then we don't let it be for nothing," Alex said, voice hoarse but steady.

He stood.

The others followed.

Together, they turned from the ruins, smoke curling behind them like ghosts from the past, and began the long walk back.

Adam had made the ultimate sacrifice.

Now, it was their turn to make it count.

2/ Chapter Eighteen

Book II – Chapter XVIII: *The Garden We Grew*

The world healed slowly, like a body stitched together by time and memory.

It wasn't perfect — no world born from ashes ever was — but the rot was gone. The skies were clean again. Cities were rebuilt, and nature rebalanced itself. There were still scars in the earth, monuments of ruin that reminded people of what once almost ended them. But those scars were lined with flowers now. Renewal. Purpose.

The group — what remained of it — each chose their own path when the rebuilding began.

Marie found her calling in a school just outside one of the new cities. She taught not just reading or numbers, but survival, history, ethics — everything they had learned the hard way. She taught them about infection and cure, pain and healing. She never named herself a hero, but in the eyes of her students, she was one.

Marianna disappeared into a quiet town nestled in the hills. There, she lived with her partner and raised two children — strong, curious, beautiful kids who never had to see the world as it had been. She gardened, cooked, protected her peace. When asked about the past, she would smile, shake her head, and say, "You wouldn't believe it."

Jadrien, to everyone's surprise — maybe even his own — wrote books. Dozens of them. Stories of the old world, the infestation, the firelit nights they'd shared. The books were stylized, dramatic, often funny, but they held truth. Truth wrapped in fiction. In every library, his works were tucked somewhere between myth and memoir.

Michael went back to what he knew — structure, purpose, duty. He rose through the new military's ranks with steadiness and steel resolve. He trained the next generation not in war, but in discipline and choice. Peacekeeping, not power. He kept a photo of their group tucked into his vest pocket every day.

Robert vanished for a while. When word finally caught up to him, he was living in the countryside alone — quiet, simple, untouched by the noise. He didn't want medals or purpose. He tended to an orchard, brewed his own coffee, and once in a while, sent short letters with one or two lines that always made someone cry.

Sage became a star.

Her first movie — *Ashes and Automatons* — was a cinematic retelling of their story, stylized, sure, but raw with truth. It earned awards. It made people cry. It made people remember. She never hid who she was, never glamorized it. And in every interview, she said, "I'm just playing the life we all lived."

Alex became the youngest head inventor the new military had ever seen. The boy who once hid behind corners now stood behind schematics and blueprints, building defense systems not to

dominate but to protect. He never stopped tinkering. He never stopped imagining. His inventions saved lives — hundreds of them. But every prototype bore the initials A.H. etched somewhere small and hidden, in memory.

But even as they moved on, even as the years settled like dust over the past, there was one thing they never let go of.

The old brick house.

They maintained it together. No one lived in it. No one altered it. It stayed exactly as it had been — as Adam had made it. They repaired the roof when it sagged, repainted the porch, even let vines grow over one side, just the way he'd liked. It became a ritual.

Once a year — always the same day — they returned.

They'd sit in the courtyard, sometimes in silence, sometimes in laughter. They'd cook together, drink, share stories. Sometimes new friends or family members came with them, but the core group always found time. It was their place. Their shared breath of the past.

Alex was the last to arrive this year. He carried a satchel full of tools and a box of preserved tea he knew Marie liked. His hair had grown longer, tucked back now, and he wore a coat with far too many inside pockets. The others were already there, already laughing about something Robert had said.

They embraced him one by one — older now, softer in places, scarred in others, but whole. Somehow, miraculously, whole.

The sun dipped low.

They lit lanterns.

They sat around the same fire pit they had once feared for their lives beside. And now, they talked about lives lived — about children, about mistakes, about roles they never imagined they'd play.

It was Sage who said it first. "Do you think he'd be proud?"

No one had to ask who.

"I think," said Marie, pouring herself a cup of tea, "he'd be *smirking*."

That drew laughter.

"I think he'd say, 'Took you long enough,'" Jadrien added with a grin.

"I think he'd tell me I should bring the kids around more," Marianna teased, prompting another round of chuckles.

And then...

There it was.

A sharp, deliberate *click*. A rhythmic metallic tap against stone.

They turned.

From the shadow of the treeline, it stepped forward. Sleek black metal, eyes glowing softly like ember. Perched proud and regal, its head tilted at a curious angle.

The crow.

The one that had always watched. The one that had vanished when Adam had.

It stood on the low brick wall surrounding the fire pit.

And then—

In Adam's voice, familiar and bright:

“Hey, so how are we doing today?”

The group froze.

Not in fear.

But in something like awe.

And in that silence — the last echo of the past and the promise of the future — the fire crackled gently.

2/ Finale

The End

Thanks For Reading